Newspaper article undated by Brian J Porte on work of Maria Ierullo re: translation and community services in Dalhousie Ward Ottawa			Many immigrants to Ottawa who were part of the huge influx that followed the Second World War arrived with little or no knowledge of Canada's official languages. They were helped to settle into Ottawa by individuals like Maria Ierullo who knew how to navigate the system. The church of St Anthony of Padua also played a large role in settlement. Demand outstripped community resources and people were pretty much on their own. Maria had the drive, knowledge, skills, contacts within the Italian and mainstream community , commitment and personality to be able forge a pioneering career as a real estate broker, translator and community activist with providing help on a volunteer basis.

Language barrier in Dalhousie

Translators offer valuable assistance

By Brian J. Porter

It was a simple accident, the kind that happens every day on hundreds of streets in hundreds of cities.

The driver had run a stop sign. No serious damage, but police said a charge would have to be laid.

Under any other circumstances there would have been no problem. But this time it wasn't so simple.

The driver was Italian and spoke only broken English. The English-speaking officer did not speak any Italian. A translator would be required to help explain the charge.

Suddenly the language barrier is transformed into an object of frustration. The policeman is hindered from performing his duty; the driver is confused and defenceless.

To many members of the large Italian community in Dalhousie Ward, the language barrier is a basic handicap.

Close to a fifth of the ward's residents are Italian and 90 per cent still speak Italian at home, says Edda Battistella, vice-president of the Italian Centre. The centre helps to serve as a liaison between the ethnic community and the largely English-speaking world which surrounds it.

Its Office Assistance at 657 Bronson Ave. operated Monday and Thursday from 6 to 9 p.m. and provides interpreting services and assistance in personal matters.

"We help with doctor's bills, welfare cheques, rent notices, income tax forms - just about anything which may pose a problem for the immigrant," says Mrs. Battistella.

Although the volunteers who staff the centre try to provide answers to all questions, there are some problems they cannot always deal with.

One of these is in dealings with the law, where the communciation process frequently breaks down, says Sgt. Mike Cassan, community and public relations director for the Ottawa Police Department.

While Sgt. Cassan admits dealings with the police force can cause problems for immigrants, he does not think there is any resentment towards the ethnic community on the part of the force.

"It just takes a little longer to get to the root of the matter, that's all. If an officer does experience difficulty, we bring in a translator to help bridge the gap," explains Sgt. Cassan.

Bridging the gap is usually done with the aid of interpreters hired and provided by Ontario's Provincial Court.

D.J. Dupuis, Provincial Court administrator in Ottawa, says that while French interpreters are the most requested in this city, the demand for Italian translators ranks second.

Although there are always at least two full-time French interpreters employed by his department, Italian translators are required only periodically. They are called in when needed from a list of ethnic translators who provide their services on a part-time bases.

Mary Ierullo, a realtor, has been on that list for 22 years and is often a valuable link between cultures since she is fluent in many of the different Italian dialects, says Mr. Dupuis.

While she may be called at any time by the court office, Mrs. Ierullo is frequently approached privately at her realty business at 237 Rochester St.

Like the Italian Centre's Office of Assistance, she provides interpretive services and help for many problems, "whether it be understanding a bill from the phone company or having to face a first-time appearance in court," she says.

Mrs. Ierullo says that for many residents of the Italian community, the threat of English assimilation is their biggest concern.

"My people are very proud of their heritage," she explains, "and sometimes try to resist the English influence."

Although it is difficult to pinpoint just how much resistance there actully is, Phil Piazza, community liaison officer for the Dalhousie Area Study, says: Many people are aware of the problem and are trying to deal with it.

He cites an effort which he made to prompt Italian input into the Dalhousie study.

"We tried to get two Italians involved by having them participate in a bilingual (Italian-English) discussion. After the first five minutes one of them walked out."

Photo by Brian J. Porter

Mary Ierullo, translator